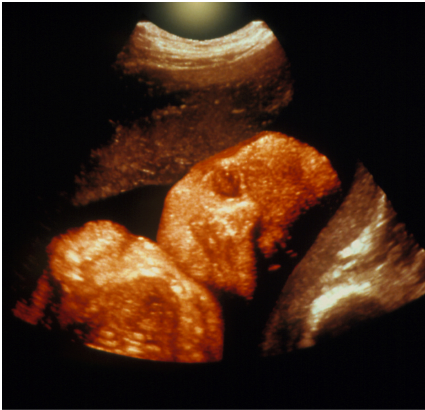




YOU ARE **31 WEEKS AND 6 DAYS**

57 days to go

YOUR BABY TODAY

This image shows the amount of amniotic fluid is around your baby at this time. Ultrasound displays the fluid as black on the screen. Sometimes there will be speckles within the fluid: these represent skin and hair cells that are shed as your baby grows.

“If your third trimester coincides with the summer months, staying cool and comfortable can be a real challenge.”

When the weather is hot, your baby makes it sweltering! Keep yourself hydrated by drinking lots of cool water. Consider carrying a spray bottle of water (keep it in the fridge overnight so that it's nice and cold the next day) to spritz you when you're too hot.

Opt for sleeveless clothing that is made of natural fabrics, such as linen and cotton, which will help keep the air circulating. If you want to keep some or all of your arms covered, wear short-sleeved jackets or cotton cardigans. Wear a sun hat and sunglasses, especially if you're in direct sunlight for any length of time.

Opt for flip-flops or low-heeled sandals to let your feet breathe—these can also be a good option if your feet are swollen (see [Swollen feet, ankles, hands, and wrists](#)).

LISTENING TO YOUR BABY'S HEARTBEAT

From the very earliest stages of pregnancy, your baby's heart will be beating, and there can be nothing more uplifting and reassuring than hearing this for yourself. Your doctor can use a variety of instruments to hear your baby's heartbeat, including a stethoscope and a Doppler monitor, which uses ultrasound technology (see [First hours and days](#)). A baby's heart beats between 120 and 160 times per minute (with slight variations)—quite a few more than your own heartbeat, which is normally under 100. The sole purpose of listening to the heartbeat is to ensure that it falls within a normal range, and to reassure moms-to-be that all is well. If there's an unusual rhythm or the heartbeat speeds or slows unexpectedly, your doctor can arrange for tests to confirm that all is well. Some women feel that hearing their baby's heartbeat helps the bonding process in advance of the birth.

FIRST HOURS AND DAYS

To help you prepare for what to expect in the first few days after your baby is born, here are a few interesting facts you might like to know: